

Rethinking case attraction on Ancient Greek infinitive clauses

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1 Introduction

Good morning. The reasons behind why the pair of sentences in (1) show different agreement/concord patterns remains largely unknown.

- (1) a. συμβουλεύει τῷ Ξενοφῶντι ἐλθόντα εἰς Δελφοὺς ἀνακοινῶσαι τῷ θεῷ περὶ τῆς πορείας.
He advises Xenophon to go to Delphi and ask the god about the travel. (Xen. *Anab.* 3.1.5)
- b. ἀφῆκε μοι ἐλθόντι πρὸς ὑμᾶς λέγειν τὰληθῆ.
He allowed me to go and speak the truth in front of you. (Xen. *Hell.* 6.1.13)

[Self-deprecatingly] I myself have, in the last edition of this event, tried to present the patterns that make the attraction result, (1-b), more likely, arguing that the classes of the matrix and infinitive verbs and the relative distance and position of the controller and target of agreement were the most important factors.

Furthermore, I argued that these factors were but *proxies* to unseen variables, namely semantic and pragmatic features of the discourse setting, and that even in the absence of seen contrasting factors, precisely the case in the pair above (1), the unseen discourse factors would be still causing one resolution to be at the very least more likely.

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[Introducingly] I wasn't, however, quite convinced about neither the methods, data, and, most of all, quality of the results I arrived at. The reasons for such distrust will become clearer later. So this will be a more rigorous tentative to approach the problem.

The aim of this paper is to walk through the assumptions present in my own and other's assessments of the phenomenon, as I believe most of them are in themselves right, build from these assumptions a causal system and show how much of this system is left unexplained with what we do know and, more importantly, I believe, what we **can** know and measure about ancient languages in general.

2 The data

Before stepping into the framework and analysis proper, a brief word on the empirical data supporting this research and any conclusion coming from it. The dataset is composed of 343 sentences drawn from the Attic literary *corpus* and Herodotus. The sentences were extracted from the Diorisis Corpus (Vatri and McGillivray 2018, 2020) with help of the project's querying tool, Diorisis Search (Vatri 2020-2022). Although comprehensive, the selection is by no means exhaustive.

Each sentence has been annotated for values of interest, including authorship, literary genre, dialect as well as class of matrix and infinitive verb, class of controller and target, distance between constituents, etc. Parts of the annotation processes were conducted programmatically and later checked manually.

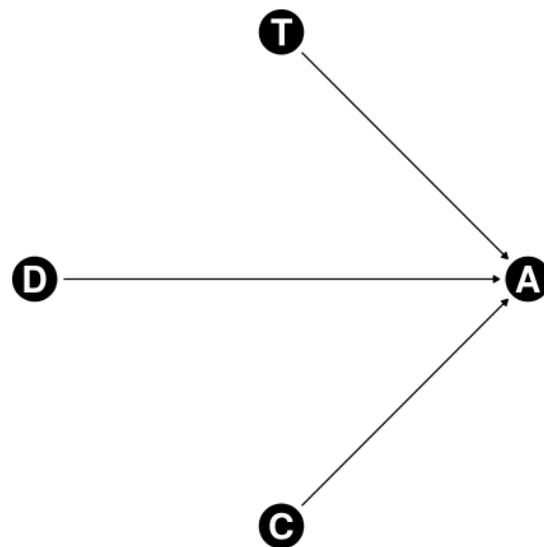
3 Nature of attraction

In the most abstract way possible, case attraction in infinitive clauses, exemplified by (1-b), is when two constituents, a controller and a target, produced in different domains of a sentence, one of the domains encompassing the other, covary in an specific feature, namely [*Case*]. This satisfies the definition of agreement in Corbett's typological assessment of the phenomenon across languages (2006, pp. 4–7).

The lack of covariation of the [*Case*] feature, seen in (1-a), is generally understood as result of the application of **default** case concord rules of Ancient Greek. This assumes that the subject of infinitive clauses in Greek is always marked as accusative, even when not overtly expressed, and that convert constituents are also marked for [*Case*] and its case is also available for nominal concord.

The facts that the target has a choice of controller (either the overt oblique or de convert accusative) for agreement, that [*Case*] is a non-lexical features, that the agreement is optional, and that the domain is non-local favours the interpretation that the agreement type of case attraction is less canonical than the general agreement type of Ancient Greek, following the criteria for canonical agreement in the same work of Corbett (2006, pp. 8ff.).

If this assessment is sound, it is expected that attraction and non-attraction behave as competing agreement resolutions, the former being less canonical and thus more likely to be conditioned. Conditions concerning the semantic and pragmatic properties of the controller, its precedence in relation to the target and the class of predication (i.e.: class of the domain) have been identified by Corbett. Although properties of the target were not shown to be favouring any resolution in agreement mismatches in Corbett's survey, case attraction might be one example of it, and I will hypothesize that properties of targets are competing causes of non-canonical resolutions. A model of agreement in this framework may be represented as a direct acyclic graph, in which Attraction is caused by features of the Controller, Domain and Target:



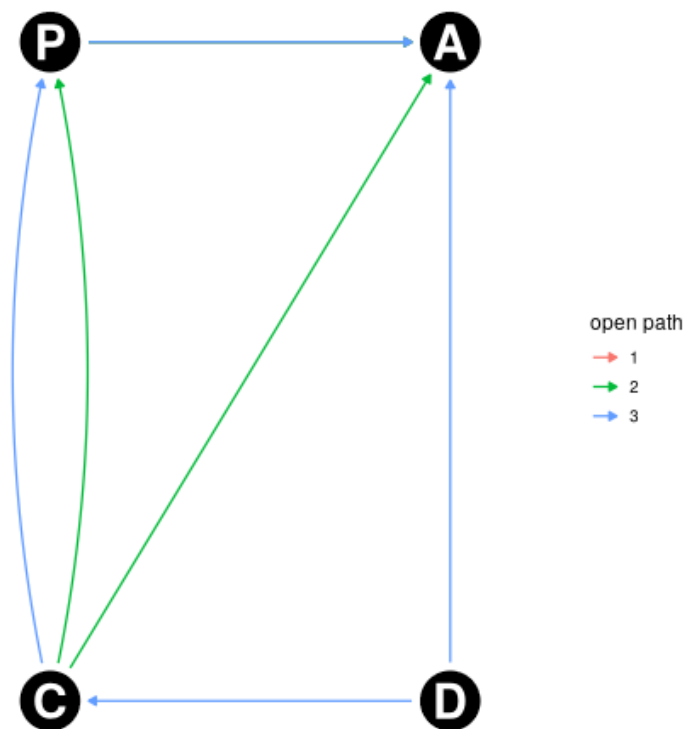
4 The domain of attraction

Firstly, many have associated case attraction with sentences in which the infinitival clause is a copular infinitive, an *einai* or *genesthai*. Should the class of the infinitive favour either resolution of agreement? Probably not directly, as there

is no reason linguistically it would. Copular infinitives, however, have a double effect on the agreement “causes”:

1. they filter the possible relations between controller and target, as those are now more likely in primary predication, rather than secondary or appositive relation;
2. this then delimits the option of target, making it more likely that they are nouns or adjectives, rather than participles.

Going for a schema, let’s say that Attraction is caused by the type of Relation (more or less predicative, or attributive) and by the Part of Speech of the Target, which is itself partially caused by the Relation.



5 The controller of attraction

Another association is that between case attraction and impersonal verbs. I have, however, shown that this association does not exist with every single impersonal verb, and that the verb *δοκέω* almost never heads a sentence with case attraction. The impersonal verbs which are actually associated with case attraction are those carrying modal semantics, such as *ἐξαρκεῖ* and *ἐξέστί*. Is it likely that

the nature of the matrix verb directly affects the choice of agreement? I don't think so, but it may indirectly do, by defining which features the controller of agreement, the oblique object, has. These verbs have very little semantic information and the theta role and grammatical function of their oblique object seems to depend on the infinitive verb. We may say that σοι in (1), for example, is the subject of the sentence (a quirk subject of sorts) and has the thematic role of agent, much in contrast if the sentence was constructed with a verb of order or advice like συμβουλεύω.

- (1) ἄλλ' ἔξαρκῇ σοι τὰ ἔργα αὐτῶν ὁρῶντι σέβεσθαι καὶ τιμᾶν τοὺς θεούς.
But it is enough for you to look at these deeds and respect the gods. (Xen.
Mem. 4.3.13)

6 The target of attraction

Finally, it has been long been proposed that case agreement is more likely when controller and target are very close to each other, and the likelihood diminishes as it grows. I have previously showed that, although very much associated, long distance between controller and target is not a dependable predictor for lack of attraction, but that precedence of the target in relation to the controller seems to demand case attraction, such as in (1).

- (1) ὥς ἀγαθοῖς τε ὑμῖν προσήκει εἶναι.
That you may be good people. (Xen. *Anab.* 3.2.11)

As with the previous factors, we must ask: are distance and precedence directly causing case attraction, or are they indirect causes? Longer distances have been shown to favour non-canonical agreement resolutions in other languages, such as with personal pronouns agreeing with committee nouns in English, which are more likely to be plural the further away from their controller. This is the very opposite of what is being proposed for case attraction: the canonical agreement (the local one) is the one becoming more likely as farther away the target is from the controller.

References

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